

Beyond Guilt

Game Design Document (Production Version)

Version: 1.0 (Pre-Production)

Engine: Unity 6 (URP)

Language: C#

Platform: Windows (Steam)

Developer: Advait (Solo)

Development Time

- Demo (Vertical Slice): 6 Weeks
- Full Release: +4 Weeks

Genre

- First-Person Psychological Judgment Simulator

Camera

- First Person (Limited Rotation)

Art Style

- Low Poly
- PS2 / Early PS3 Inspired
- Stylized Realism

1. Game Overview

High Concept

Beyond Guild is a courtroom management game where the player serves as the Judge of the Afterlife. Every day, five criminal souls stand trial. The player investigates their crimes, questions them, delivers a verdict, and assigns an eternal punishment.

Each judgment permanently changes Hell. Punishment facilities evolve, the Judge's reputation spreads, and future souls adapt their behavior based on previous decisions.

Core Fantasy

> Become the architect of eternal justice.

Target Session

15–25 minutes per in-game day.

Target Audience

Players who enjoy:

- Moral dilemmas
- Detective games
- Strategy & management
- Narrative simulations

2. Core Pillars

These are the foundation of Beyond Guild. Every mechanic in the game should support at least one of these pillars.

1. Investigation

Every case presents incomplete or conflicting information. The player must analyze evidence, identify contradictions, and understand the criminal before making a judgment.

Goal: Discover the truth.

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2. Judgment

The player decides the criminal's fate based on their own philosophy of justice. There are no objectively correct answers in most cases—only consequences.

Goal: Deliver a fair verdict.

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3. Hell Management

Judged souls become part of Hell. Punishment facilities evolve over time, affecting Hell's stability, capacity, and overall state.

Goal: Maintain a stable and functioning afterlife.

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4. Adaptive Souls

Future souls learn from the Judge's past decisions. They may become more fearful, manipulative, honest, or deceptive depending on the Judge's reputation and Hell's current state.

Goal: Adapt to an ever-changing courtroom.

3. Core Gameplay Loop

The game is played in **daily cycles**, with each day consisting of **5 criminal cases**.

Start Day

↓

Review Hell Overview

↓

Investigate Case

↓

Question the Soul

↓

Deliver Verdict

↓

Assign Punishment

↓

Repeat (5 Cases)

↓

Review Daily Report

↓

Next Day

Gameplay Flow

Start Day

The player begins by reviewing Hell's current condition, including punishment facilities, stability, and emerging issues.

Investigate Case

Analyze evidence, witness statements, and case files to understand the crime.

Question the Soul

Interrogate the criminal to uncover motives, expose lies, or verify evidence.

Deliver Verdict

Decide whether the soul is guilty and determine the appropriate judgment based on the available information.

Assign Punishment

Choose the punishment facility where the soul will spend eternity. Each facility has different long-term effects on Hell and its inhabitants.

Repeat

Complete a total of **5 cases** before the day ends.

Review Daily Report

Receive a summary of:

- Today's judgments
- Hell's updated condition

- Facility changes
- Judge reputation
- Soul adaptation trends

Next Day

Hell updates, souls adapt to the Judge's decisions, and a new set of cases begins.

Player Goal

Throughout the game, the player must balance two responsibilities:

- **Deliver fair and consistent justice.**
- **Maintain a stable and sustainable afterlife.**

4. Core Mechanics

Interrogation

Question the soul to uncover motives, expose lies, or gather additional information.

Judgment

Deliver a verdict based on the available evidence and your philosophy of justice.

Sentencing

Assign the soul to a punishment facility. Each punishment has unique long-term effects on Hell.

Hell Simulation

Every sentenced soul becomes part of Hell, affecting facility conditions, stability, and future events.

Soul Adaptation

Future souls adapt their courtroom behavior based on the Judge's reputation and previous judgments.

Daily Reports

At the end of each day, review the consequences of today's decisions before beginning the next day.

5. Hell Management

Overview

Every sentenced soul enters Hell, where punishments continue indefinitely. The player's decisions directly influence Hell's growth, stability, and future courtroom behavior.

Punishment Facilities

Each punishment has:

- Capacity
- Population
- Efficiency
- Stability

- Special Effect

Examples:

- Wrath Pit
- Isolation Chamber
- Empathy Chamber

Hell Overview

At the start of each day, the player reviews:

- Hell Stability
- Total Souls
- Chaos Level
- Facility Status
- Judge Reputation

This helps plan the day's judgments.

Daily Report

After 5 cases, the player receives:

- Today's Judgments
- Facility Updates
- Hell Status
- Soul Behaviour Analysis
- Emerging Trends

Judge Reputation

The Judge develops a reputation based on previous decisions, influencing how future souls behave during trials.

Examples:

- Merciful
- Harsh
- Balanced
- Consistent

Soul Adaptation

Souls learn from the Judge's past decisions.

Examples:

- Fearful souls confess sooner.
- Manipulative souls fake remorse.
- Repeat offenders exploit predictable judgments.
- Honest souls become more cooperative.

This ensures every playthrough evolves differently.

6. Progression

New Cases

As days progress, cases become more complex, introducing conflicting evidence, moral dilemmas, and unpredictable criminals.

New Punishments

Unlock new punishment facilities as Hell expands, giving the player more sentencing options and strategic choices.

Hell Evolution

Hell grows based on the player's judicial philosophy. Facilities visually and mechanically evolve as they receive more souls.

Judge Evolution

The Judge's reputation develops over time, changing how future souls approach trials.

Increasing Challenge

Difficulty increases through:

- Smarter souls
- Better manipulation
- Harder investigations
- Facility overcrowding
- Rising instability
- New Hell events

Multiple Endings

The ending is determined by:

- Judge Reputation
- Hell's Condition
- Judicial Philosophy
- Long-term decisions

Every playthrough creates a different version of the Afterlife.

7. World & Narrative

Premise

The player serves as the Judge of the Afterlife, responsible for deciding the eternal fate of criminal souls.

Setting

The game takes place entirely within the Afterlife, primarily inside the Courtroom and Hell.

Daily Structure

Each day, five criminal souls arrive for trial. Their crimes span different eras, cultures, and backgrounds.

Story Progression

The narrative unfolds through:

- Criminal cases
- Soul interactions
- Hell's evolution
- Judge reputation
- Major world events

Themes

- Justice vs Revenge
- Truth vs Perception
- Punishment vs Redemption
- Consequences of Power

Player Choice

There are no objectively correct philosophies. Every decision shapes the Afterlife and leads to a different outcome.

8. UI / UX

Main Screens

- Main Menu
- Courtroom
- Hell Overview
- Daily Report
- Settings

Courtroom UI

Displays:

- Case Information
- Evidence
- Dialogue Options
- Verdict
- Sentence Selection

Hell Overview

Displays:

- Hell Stability
- Total Souls
- Facility Status
- Judge Reputation
- Active Warnings

Daily Report

Displays:

- Today's Judgments
- Facility Updates
- Hell Status
- Soul Behaviour Analysis
- Emerging Trends

Design Goals

- Clean and readable
- Minimal distractions
- Dark fantasy aesthetic
- Information-first layout
- Easy navigation with minimal clicks

9. Art Direction

Visual Style

- 2D Stylized
- Dark Fantasy
- Gothic Architecture
- Minimalist UI

Environment

- Courtroom
- Hell
- Punishment Facilities

Each environment evolves visually based on the player's decisions.

Character Design

- Distinct silhouettes
- Expressive portraits
- Era-specific clothing
- Visual indicators of personality and crime

Color Palette

- Black
- Crimson
- Gold
- Grey
- Muted White

Used to emphasize authority, punishment, and contrast between order and chaos.

Visual Progression

As Hell evolves:

- Facilities expand
- Architecture changes
- Atmosphere reflects Hell's condition
- Courtroom gains visual details representing the Judge's legacy

10. Audio

Music

- Ambient orchestral soundtrack
- Dark fantasy atmosphere
- Adaptive music during major decisions

Sound Effects

- Paper handling
- Gavel strikes
- Fire and ambient Hell sounds
- Footsteps
- UI interactions

Voice

- Partial voice acting for key characters
- Unique voice profiles for souls
- Ambient courtroom chatter (where applicable)

Audio Design Goals

- Build tension during investigations
- Emphasize the weight of judgments
- Reinforce the atmosphere of the Afterlife
- Keep music subtle to avoid distracting from dialogue and decision-making

11. Technical Notes

Engine

- Unreal Engine 5

Architecture

- Data-driven case system
- Modular punishment system
- Event-driven Hell simulation
- Save/Load progression system

Core Systems

- Investigation System
- Dialogue System
- Judgment System
- Sentencing System
- Hell Simulation
- Soul AI
- Reputation System
- Daily Report System

Save Data

The game stores:

- Current Day
- Judge Reputation
- Hell State
- Facility Progress
- Soul History
- Player Decisions
- Story Progress

Scalability

The system is designed to support:

- New crime types
- New punishments
- New facilities
- New dialogue
- New endings
- Additional story events

13. RULES

- **Rule 1:** No consequence should make a case impossible to complete.
- Rule 2: No consequence can permanently remove a core mechanic during a normal run.
- Rule 3: Consequences are not permanent, they can/will be restored during the next run/day.
- Rule 4: No RPG power progression system, so correct decisions will not add additional power OR improve current choices, although it can be used to undo the consequences over time in the same run.
- Rule 5: